its attendant Augustan temple. From 1945 onwards efforts had been made to locate the famous port, initially with little success, largely because a major cyclone strike back in the fourteenth century had radically altered the coastline, diverting the mouth of the Periyar a mile or two north, silting up the old port and in the process creating what later became the harbour of Cochin. Today the focus has shifted to the hamlet of Pattanam on the south bank of the present estuary, where a series of ongoing excavations by the Kerala Council for Historical Research led by Professor P. J. Cherian have so far uncovered a brick-lined wharf studded with teak bollards and some early Roman amphorae and glassware, as well as medieval Arabian glazed pottery and Chinese porcelain. But, as yet, no signs of an Augustan temple.

The number of Roman coins found throughout what was then Satavahana territory shows that this was something of a golden age, more funded by trade than conquest. It was Rome's precious metals that paid for the Vedic sacrifices listed by that pious couple of son and mother Raja Satakarni I and Rani Naganika on the walls of the Naneghat rock-cut cave, besides giving them and their successors the security to accommodate and even patronise other faiths within their empire.

The reader will not be surprised to learn that the first serious collector of Satavahana coinage was that remarkable self-made scholar Bhagwan Lal Indraji. When a certain Surgeon-Major Codrington read his paper 'Coins of Andhrabhritya kings of South India' to members of the Bombay branch of the Royal Asiatic Society in Bombay in September 1877, he had the grace to acknowledge that it had been prepared 'from information given by Pandit Bhagvanlal Indraji, honorary member of the Society'. Much of Indraji's collection is now in the British Museum, which received no fewer than 1809 early coins from him in the form of a bequest.